reports about mothers defaulting on payments. So, notices have been sent to errant mothers saying only those making payments to colleges in time will get the next tranche. Implementation of the slew of welfare schemes is tracked through the elaborate village and ward secretariat network by the 11,162 village and 3,842 ward secretariats in urban areas.

Education and health initiatives remain major concerns on Jagan's welfare agenda. Between June 2019 and October 2021, as many as 1,374,087 persons availed treatment through YSR Arogyasri, costing the state Rs 4,828.7 crore. About 95 per cent families in the state enjoy its benefits as eligibility now covers those with annual incomes of up to Rs 5 lakh.

Analysts point out how the majority of the welfare schemes are without concomitant development in the form of investments that could create jobs. Uncertainty over the tri-capital plan with Visakhapatnam, Amaravati and Kurnool as the nodes has also become a deterrent for potential investors wary of legal wrangles. "We are witness to the most egregious financial indiscipline ever seen in the history of India," says a retired bureaucrat. Analysts also say that in the past year, the YSRC government has taken loans that were equal to the total amount of loans availed by the previous government and suggest the government should come clean with a white paper on the finances in view of the alarming reports that it has taken loans in violation of rules and in excess of the FRBM. Banks and financial institutions are now reluctant to lend to the state unless assets are mortgaged.

THE LONG GAME

MUDDYING THE WATERS IS THE political acrimony between the YSRC and TDP which shows no sign of abating. It touched a new low on October 19 when TDP leaders, including party spokesperson Kommareddy Pattabhiram, used the choicest expletives against Jagan and the YSRC. In a swift payback, YSRC cadre stormed the TDP headquarters and ransacked it to show their might even as the police arrested Pattabhiram for abusing constitutional authorities. A peeved Naidu then sat on a 36-hour strike at the party headquarters before petitioning President Ram Nath Kovind to declare President's rule in Andhra Pradesh. The YSRC, in a counter-petition, asked the President to derecognise the TDP "for its failure to maintain decency and decorum in public life...." The latest in this unsavoury battle had Naidu breaking down at a media conference and declaring that he will boycott the assembly for the rest of Jagan's term. Political commentator K. Nageshwar says, "Jagan has a huge mandate that could have been used to focus on governance. Instead, the YSRC is unnecessarily indulging in acrimony and controversies."

Some critics argue that this is all part of Jagan's strategy to destroy his rivals. "His is a highly centralised, intolerant and one-sided style of governance and this attempt to implement such unsustainable electoral promises will ruin the state," says former Andhra Pradesh chief secretary



TEARS FOR FEARS Opposition leader and TDP chief Naidu breaks down at a press meet

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ANALYSTS POINT OUT THAT IN THE PAST YEAR, THE YSRC GOVERNMENT HAS ALREADY TAKEN LOANS EQUAL TO THE TOTAL AMOUNT AVAILED BY THE PREVIOUS REGIME AND SUGGEST IT COME CLEAN WITH A WHITE PAPER ON THE STATE'S FINANCES

and now BJP activist I.Y.R. Krishna Rao. Others believe that Jagan, who turns 50 on December 21, has a strongman's clarity of purpose. "He is pretty much a single man army, very much his own man. He has a sharp memory, particularly for numbers. Jagan's goal is to remain in power for a long time, enrich himself as well as those who have been with him, while also keeping the vote bank intact and stifling the opposition," says a bureaucrat who has watched him closely. Seldom does he consult cabinet colleagues or even his appointed advisors. Only party MP V. Vijaya Sai Reddy, Sajjala Ramakrishna and Jagan's maternal uncle Y.V. Subba Reddy, who has now got a second term as chairman of the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD), are known to have his ear.

Meanwhile, Jagan has no dearth of plans for the state, the latest being reorganising the districts to almost double their number—13 to 25. This implies making fresh promises even as some post-poll ones like the opening of new medical colleges in each existing district along with a super specialty hospital have made little headway beyond Jagan virtually laying the foundation stones simultaneously. ■